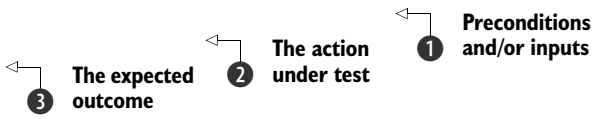
```
Given <a context>
When <something happens>
Then <we expect some outcome>
```



This is a simple yet surprisingly versatile format. It helps you cleanly define the context of a test ❶, what action is being tested ❷, and what the expected outcome should be ❸. It also helps you focus on what the requirement aims to achieve, rather than on how it will do so.

Let's look at each of these steps in more detail.

GIVEN SETS THE STAGE

The `Given` step describes the preconditions for your test. It sets up any test data your test needs and generally puts the application in the correct pretest state. Typically, this includes things such as creating any required test data, or, for a web application, logging on and navigating to the right page. Sometimes a `Given` step may be purely informative, to provide some context or background, even if no action is required in the test implementation.

You should be careful to only include the preconditions that are directly related to the scenario. Additional `Given`s make it harder for a reader to know precisely what's required for the scenario to work. In the same way, preconditions that should be present in the `Given` steps, but that aren't, are effectively assumptions that can lead to misunderstandings later on.

WHEN CONTAINS THE ACTION UNDER TEST

The `When` step describes the principal action or event that you want to test. This could be a user performing some action on a website, or some other non-UI event, such as processing a transaction or handling an event message. This action will generate some observed outcome, which you'll verify in the `Then` step.

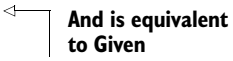
THEN DESCRIBES THE EXPECTED OUTCOMES

The `Then` step compares the observed outcome or state of the system with what you expect. The outcome should tie back to the business value you expect to get out of the story or feature this scenario belongs to.

5.2.4 Ands and buts

In both Gerkin and JBehave, any of the previous steps can be extended using `and`. Gherkin also allows you to use the synonym `but`. You've seen this before:

```
Scenario: Earning standard points from an Economy flight
Given the flying distance between Sydney and Melbourne is 878 km
And I am a standard Frequent Flyer member
When I fly from Sydney to Melbourne
Then I should earn 439 points
```



Technically, the BDD tools consider any step with `And` or `But` to be the same as the previous step that wasn't `And` or `But`. The main goal is to make the scenarios read more easily.